

16. Towards a theory of aesthetic rhythm

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1. Introduction

In versification studies, rhythm has been a wide and loose concept. Meter is thoroughly investigated, but modern free verse requires other tools. All kinds of poetry have rhythm, of course. In a way, everything shows some kind of rhythm—seasons, moonlight, brainwaves, etc.—the word ‘rhythm’ has been used very broadly. What, then, is really relevant and possible to investigate? In 2006, I took part in the arrangement of a symposium in Göteborg, collecting the most distinguished Scandinavian scholars in the field of aesthetic rhythm. The symposium resulted in a report where we listed nine areas for future research (Lilja et al. 2006). Firstly, we established some theoretical standpoints:

1. Rhythm is regarded as a psychological feature rather than as a property of the work of art—which, on the other hand, of course has properties that trigger the experience of rhythm.
2. Several investigations of rhythm presuppose an understanding of musical meter. However, this idea is too narrow. The dancing body should be the starting point for the study of rhythm. It is both spatial and temporal, which may explain why we use the word ‘rhythm’ about e.g. cathedrals, sculptures, music and poetry. The dancing body forms a stable *gestalt*. The meeting between body and world is both natural as well as culturally/conventionally produced.
3. Rhythm should be seen as preconditioned by sensuous experience. Vision and hearing give us the incitements of rhythm, but the experience of rhythm should be situated in the sensory-motor capacities, and in ideated sensations, that is, internalized memories of sensuous experience that affect present perceptions.

We made a list of problems possible to investigate:

4. Repetition. Rhythm emerges when form elements are related to each other. They relate through being repeated or, in other words, they have a certain likeness to each other. The term ‘equivalence’ means sameness or similarity (Roman

Jakobson). The person who experiences a rhythm compares one form element to another. The beat, or pulse, holds a special position in its extreme conformity.

5. Cognition. Rhythmic experience exists in the tension between universal, *cognitive* experience and culturally determined aesthetic *conventions*. The cognitive factors are specifically the experience of movement, direction, force-dynamics and balance. The conventional factors consist of adequate, historically determined *gestalt* patterns, e.g. versification patterns. How does one distinguish what is cultural and what is universal in the rhythm of a poem?
6. Balance. *Balance* was discussed as a key concept in relation to sensuous capacities. We observed that the symmetry of form elements is influenced by an endeavor for asymmetry (dynamic repetition). How does this interplay of balance and divergence work in a poem, and how does it relate to the equivalences of point 4?
7. Levels. Rhythmic segments are related both to each other, and to other rhythmic levels in the work of art. Every part relates to a hierarchically greater part, which in turn relates to the whole. The interplay of different *gestalt* levels creates *polyrhythmics*. How does one describe this interplay and its effects?
8. Time. Rhythm affects the experience of *time*, which can be automatized or de-automatized. Rhythm can be a means to synchronization. Is it possible to systematize this observation?

Finally we made a statement about meaning production:

9. Rhythms produce meaning, probably by activating internalized bodily experiences as well as conventional meaning patterns developed from social practices and cultural traditions. The segments of rhythm in a work of art are diffuse signs; they lack the evident semantic meaning of words but they still have meaning or signification. This should be seen as a particular kind of meaning production. Delayed categorization produces time for such extra meaning to come into play (Tsur 2008:577f.). Such diffuse signs first and foremost produce meaning of attitude and feeling, but they can also influence factual content by applying displacements and perspectives.

Here I will leave points 5 and 8 for future research and focus especially on point 4 and 6, discussing some rhythmical problems in four poems, two in Swedish and two in English. I will also propose that rhythm might be constructed according to three basic principles: serial, segmental and dynamic rhythm (Hopsch & Lilja 2007:364).

2. Movement and direction in a poem by Tranströmer

Let us take a look at a poem written by the Swedish poet Tomas Tranströmer in his youth in 1958. A more detailed analysis of this poem is under publication (Lilja 2009).

- På natten klockan två: månsken. Tåget har stannat
 2 mitt ute på slätten. Långt borta ljuspunkter i en stad,
 flimrande kallt vid synranden.
- 4 Som när en människa gått in i en dröm så djupt
 att hon aldrig ska minnas att hon var där
 6 när hon återvänder till sitt rum.
- Och som när någon gått in i en sjukdom så djupt
 8 att allt som var hans dagar blir några flimrande punkter, en svärm,
 kall och ringa vid synranden.
- 10 Tåget står fullkomligt stilla.
 Klockan två: starkt månsken, få stjärnor.
 (Spår, *Hemligheter på vägen*, 1958)

At night at two o'clock: moonlight. The train has stopped / out at the plain. Far away lights of a city, / flickering coldly at the horizon. // Like when a man has gone into a dream so deeply / that she never will remember that she was there / when she returns to her room. // And like when someone has gone into an illness so deeply / that everything that was his days turns into some flickering points, a swarm / cold and small at the horizon. // The train stands totally still. / Two o'clock: strong moonlight, a few stars. // (Tracks, *Secrets on the Road*, 1958)

What is going on in this poem? A train stops in the middle of the night. First this is compared to a dreaming man ("she"), and then to a sick person's ("he") weak memories of a normal life. The last stanza returns to the immobile train. Here the lights from a distant city are replaced with moonlight. The rhythm of the poem could be notated like this:

		<u>prominences</u>	<u>syllable stress ratio</u>
	o O ooo O / OO // O oo O o	2 + 2 + 2 = 6	2.2 (3 1 2.5)
2	O ooo O o // OO o / OO ooo O	2 2 3	7 2.1 (3 1.5 2)
	O oo O / o OO o	2 2	4 2 (2 2)
4	ooo O ooo O oo O / o O >	3 1	4 3.3 (3.7 2)
	oo O oo O o / oo OO	2 2	4 2.8 (3.5 2)
6	oo O o O ooo O	3(2)	3 3 3
	ooo O oo O oo OO / o O >	4(3) 1	5 2.6 (2.8 2)
8	o O ooo O o / ooo O oo O o / o O	2 2 1	5 3.4 (3.5 4 2)
	O o O o / o OO o	2 2	4 2 (2 2)
10	O o O / O O o O o	2 3(2)	5 1.6 (1.5 1.7)
	oo O / OOO / OO o	1 3 2	6 1.5 (3 1 1.5)

[Explanations:

O = prominence, strong syllable; o = weak syllable; 0 = weak prominence; **O** = phrasal focus

/ = pause, phrase limit; // = a longer pause; > = enjambment

Syllable stress ratio expresses the relationship between strong and weak positions of a line. 1 = all syllables are prominent, 2 = one half of the syllables are prominent, 3 = one third of the syllables are prominent, etc.]

Of course it would be possible to realise the rhythm in other ways than the one which is notated here. I have tried to read the poem as normally as possible, considering grammar and prosody, but of course I have a pre-understanding or an interpretation of the poem, which has governed my choices.

Tranströmer has been interested in religious mysticism all his life, and he has tried to find modern expressions for it like in this poem, where he describes slipping out of ordinary reality for a moment with the help of a most modern train. The universal man of the poem changes between “he” and “she”. The rhythmic analysis aims at an understanding of whether or not rhythm and semantics are cooperating.

How does rhythm work in the text? A train stands still in the first stanza, and the rhythm does not move very much either. The core concept of moving rhythm is to be specified here in accordance with metrical tradition, where one talks about falling and rising measures. Falling movement is defined as starting with a prominence, and rising means movement towards a prominent syllable, which occurs later. On the level of the sequence, a forward movement implies that the significant goal is to be found in the end of the phrase. In this poem, forward movements are changing with lack of movement.

‘Stillness’ will here refer to phrases and lines in balance or equilibrium.

In line 1, for example, the prominences are almost in perfect balance around the spondee in the middle. Rhythm and meaning are cooperating. The second stanza is situated in a sleeper’s dream. She is moving into her inner world, and the rhythm of lines 4-5 has an energetic forward direction, especially in the cadences—the enjambment of line 4 and the closing spondee of line 5. Line 6 changes to a vague falling movement, which closes the stanza. The same pattern is repeated in the third stanza, which describes the distant inner world of a sick man. The forward rush from stanza 2 returns in lines 7-8, combined with a falling closing movement in line 9.

The fourth stanza returns to the train, which still does not move. Nor does the rhythm. Line 11 consists almost only of prominences, **o** / **ooo** / **oo** o, with a syllable stress ratio of only 1.5. Swedish normally has a syllable stress ratio between 2 and 3.

To conclude this analysis, the strongest forward movements of rhythm take place where the semantic level tells us about inner life. In this poem, rhythm infers something like ‘inner movement goes further than trains’. Rhythmic meaning adds something to the semantic meaning, shaping a narrative of its own which comments on the text. The rhythmic stillness (or balance, or equilibrium) of the first stanza gives room for the inward rush of the second and third stanzas. Lights from a distant city disappear in the fourth stanza in favour of the lights of heaven, the moon and stars. Having arrived here, the rhythm returns to standing still.

3. An audible poem and a visual one

The word ‘rhythm’ has been used for temporal events such as performances of music and poetry, and for describing visual artefacts like sculptures and paintings. Does one really mean the same thing by the word ‘rhythm’ in these two cases? Are audible and visual rhythm essentially the same phenomenon?

The Greek etymology of the very word ‘rhythm’ has something to do with *rheo* ‘floating’. Plato expressed the meaning of ‘rhythm’ as ‘ordered movement’. The *mousikē* of ancient Greece was an art form in which dance, music and poetry were performed simultaneously. The ancient choir danced while performing (Benveniste

1995:131-139). A dancing body moves in time as well as in space. The dancing body may be regarded as the prototype of rhythm.

Painting and sculpture have been looked upon as spatial art forms, and poetry and music as temporal forms. However, immediate perception takes place in both dimensions. A printed poem uses time (reading time) and space (the white paper where it is printed). Like a dancing body, the poem uses both temporal rhythms and visual rhythms; that is, rhythm has both temporal and spatial aspects. Sometimes temporality will dominate, sometimes spatiality.

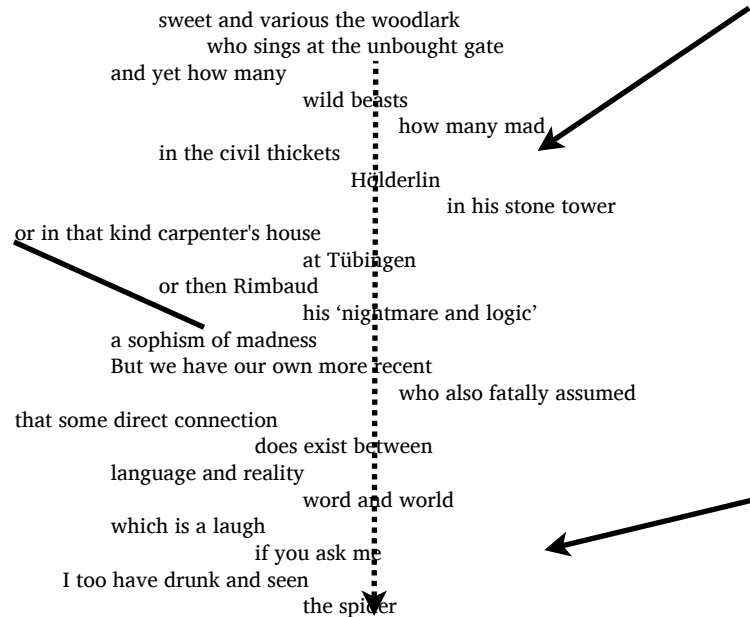
The poem is multimodal. One may listen to it or read it with the help of one's eyes. Seeing preferences the whole *gestalt*, and listening preferences the segments. A poem has at least four rhythmic levels. If one studies the poem as a whole, the printed image will dominate the impression, and the rhythm will be primarily visual. As for the stanza, rhythm is visual as well, but one might also hear its structure. The line is small enough to form an audible *gestalt*, but one may see it as well. The rhythm of a phrase, however, will not be able to be grasped by eyes—the rhythm is temporal.

- Printed image visual rhythm
- Stanza visual, audible rhythm
- Line audible, visual rhythm
- Phrase audible rhythm

4. Principles of rhythm in a poem by Ferlinghetti

I am going to point out some qualities of rhythm with the help of a poem by Lawrence Ferlinghetti, "Sweet and various the wood lark". A more thorough analysis of this poem is printed in *Changing Borders* (Hopsch & Lilja 2007:361-76). This poem about the singing lark completes Ferlinghetti's collection *A Coney Island of the Mind* (1958).

This poem is spread over the paper more loosely than one expected in 1958. Both margins are loosely waving in a way that differs both from metered stanzas and from early free versification with its typical image (a straight left margin and a slightly wavering right margin). The image differs also regarding width. It is rather narrow in the beginning, but the especially dense section in lines 11-19 gets obviously wider.



Studies of prosody have distinguished distinct versification systems in different cultures. Mikhail Gasparov has established the main systems, like French syllabic versification or Chinese syllabo-melodic versification (Gasparov 1996:3f.). In Germanic literature, we have at least three versification systems (Lilja 2006:189):

- Accentual versification of the four beat line in Norse poetry and the Middle Ages.
- Meter or tactus of the accentual syllabic poetry circa 1600-1900.
- Free versification of the Modernistic free verse.

A versification system must rely on certain rhythmic principles with additional sets of rules. The rhythmic principles of accentual versification, as well as of free verse, rely on structured sequences in combination with pronounced segmentation. The rhythmic principle of metrical forms from the Renaissance up through Romanticism is the tactus or beat.

Richard Cureton locates three so-called temporalities in poetry—tactus, grouping and prolongation (Cureton 1992:124f.). Following Cureton and Gasparov, one may classify rhythm according to three principles: serial rhythm, sequential rhythm and dynamic rhythm,

yielding three basic sets of *gestalt* qualities (Hopsch & Lilja 2007:364):

- Serial rhythm: tactus or beat in measured music and poetry.
- Sequential or segmental rhythm: the sequence or the segment of the phrase, which is to be found in free verse and in the half line of the four beat medieval line, in music and in the surface of a painting, as well as in the parts of a sculpture or a piece of architecture.
- Dynamic rhythm: the forces and directions in two- and three-dimensional artefacts, and the temporal intensification towards a focus in music and poetry.

A piece of art—in music, poetry, or sculpture—usually exemplifies two or three principles of rhythm. A drawing may consist of sequences in dynamic combinations of forces. A piece of music or a poem may consist of serial elements in a row of segments. In this poem, Ferlinghetti mixes all three principles of rhythm. The acoustic lines mix serial tactus and segmental, free rhythm. Let us take a closer look at the very last lines:

20	O oo O	segmental choriamb
21	oo OO	segmental ionicus
22	oO oO / oO >	serial iambs
23	oO o	serial iambs

The notation follows speech rhythm. Lines 20-21 use two Greek figures, the choriamb and the ionicus. An ionicus will especially not allow tactus. Those two lines exemplify sequential or segmental rhythm. The last two lines consist of four iambs. In the same way, sequential and serial rhythms vary down through the poem. Dynamic forces are added with the unsteady printed picture, where the wood lark tops the lead line with the spider at the bottom. The arrows mark visual forces bursting in from the white paper (Kandinsky 1995:102 ff.).

The poem elaborates two or three ideas of poetic language. The mirror theory (that language shows reality) is rejected in the same clause where it is mentioned (lines 14-19). Secondly, that language expresses the inner world of a person is said to be true, but it is not

appreciated (lines 7-13)—a somewhat surprising opinion to come from a poet. A possible third idea has its symbol in the singing lark. Its fluttering wings up in the air might be said to win the theoretical discussion in terms of poetic metaphor.

5. Rhythm and balance

The phenomenon of rhythm might be traced back to the experience of balance, first and foremost in the balance of a dancing body. A body in space creates directions and movements. The body moves around its axis, i.e. its point of balance. In dance rhythms, the body's balance is constantly threatened in a play between symmetry and asymmetry. Balance also entails a moment of stillness, which plays against differing directions and movements (Olsson 2006:14f.; Johnson 1987:85ff.)

The experience of rhythm awakens the body's memories of earlier experienced movements, the muscle memory. Poets used to say that they walked a poem—the poet needed to take a walk to get started. Walking seems to be the most important bodily rhythm when it comes to poetry.

Mark Johnson describes the image schema of balance. An 'image schema' is defined as a preconceptual *gestalt* governing perceptions as well as bodily movements (Johnson 1987:75). Bodily experiences settle into the most stable patterns of perception, creating unity, understanding and significance. A basic image schema of 'balance' forms a point or axis around which forces and proportions are distributed, which means that 'balance' is a balance between forces of perception (Johnson 1987:79f.)

Forces in action are most obvious in the art of sculpture, of course. Let us look at the sculpture *Unique Forms of Continuity in Space* (1913) by Umberto Boccioni (1882-1916). Boccioni, a friend of Marinetti, was part of the Futurist movement, and his work centered on the portrayal of movement and speed. Boccioni became the main theorist of their artistic circle.

Boccioni's running figure (probably Hermes on duty) is simultaneously heavy and rushing, very fast indeed. Nevertheless he is a figure in balance—otherwise the sculpture would tumble and fall. Some form elements contrast with each other (e.g. the loins) and some are repeated, strengthening each other (e.g. his parallel wind-whipped clothing). Thus Hermes illustrates a moving object interacting with the surrounding space. Compare his forward

movement with lines 4-5 in the Tranströmer poem in section 2 above. In both those pieces of art, you may find an interplay between force and balance.



Boccioni (1913): *Unique forms of continuity in space*. Digital Image © 2009, The Museum of Modern Art/SCALA, Florence.

Rhythm signifies movement, which includes an inclination toward imbalance. 'Rhythm' might be described as a balanced form heading toward imbalance, or one might define 'rhythm' as threatened balance. No balance at all means chaos, or, in other words, a lack of rhythm.

6. Balance in a poem by Fahlström

I would like to transfer this thinking into the realm of poetry via a poem by Öyvind Fahlström. It is titled “Morning in the Town Hall”, was written 1953 and printed 1966 in Fahlström’s collection *Bord ‘Tables’*. This is a poem in an *avant garde* tradition, the Swedish Concretism of the early 60s. Later on, Fahlström moved into the visual arts, joining the group of pop artists in New York, including Robert Rauschenberg and Claes Oldenburg.

Morgon i Rådhuset

det börjar bli för mycket klubbar i Rådhuset

om vi tar bort hela världen t.ex. amalgam-

känslor: han sitter gärna och skämtar, osv.

och resten är l u m p med en stövare framför	sitter han gärna och skämtar
	och resten är l u m p na och skämtar
	med en stövare framför na och skämtar
	sitter gärna och skämtar och skämtar

världen allt torrare och torrare och där

b o r t o m är allt lump badande

som hjärtan i råttlökssolar för varje hjärta sprängs en klubb aven bonde: jag k ä n n e r

som hjärtan i råttlökssolar för varje hjärta

hjärta sprängs en klubb lar för varje hjärta

av en bonde: jag k ä n n e r varje hjärta

h ä l f t e n av botten i alla bönder höjs försök att

hålla i mej när jag rusar fram genom klubben flytande bondfort

av hela världen och hälften av lumpsolen jag sitter gärna med en stövare framför

av hela världen och en stövare framför

och hälften av lumpsolen jag sitter framför

gärna med en stövare framför framför

bönder sträcks mot varandra i klubbarna

i sina rökrockar en framför varje hjärta svettandes

efter badet har dom rusat upp ur v ä r l d e n och fått stenhårda hundar till hjärtan

efter badet har dom rusat upp ur v ä r l d e n

ur v ä r l d e n och fått ur v ä r l d e n

stenhårda hundar till hjärtan ur v ä r l d e n

på dom sitter jag gärna och skämtar bortom mej och Rådhusolen

är det tyst lite riven ost ryker genom luften och vänder sej

på en femöring lump är amalgamkänslor när man tar bort alla klubbar	i Rådhuset
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på en femöring alla klubbar	i Rådhuset
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lump är amalgamkänslor när	i Rådhuset
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man tar bort alla klubbar	i Rådhuset
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och sitter på botten och sätter

stövare framför mej för att andas

mitt hjärta så att	v ä r l d e n håller sej borta från mina amalgamkänslor
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mitt hjärta så att	v ä r l d e n håller sej
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håller sej borta	v ä r l d e n håller sej
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från mina amalgamkänslor	d e n håller sej
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I will not translate the whole text, partly because it is impractical and also not necessary for my present purpose. Fahlström is playing with language in a way which is not really possible to translate. Below I will try to render the fourth and fifth line groups, which will be examined in more detail. I provide here a kind of description: there are too many clubs and too many farmers in the Town Hall. They keep joking, swimming and dining with their foxhounds. The 'I' of the poem has trouble with his composite feelings. A quick interpretation says that this might be a satire about local democracy and an old-fashioned man's role—both of them functioning badly. The language is unclean with much humour and wit.

The printed image shows a balanced spiral consisting of six swings (Elleström 2008:302-318). The first three lines of each line group grow longer and longer before the arresting short lines. This moving spiral is also to be found acoustically—six times the tempo increases and six times it decreases. The same pattern is also repeated semantically—the long lines bring about more information, which is repeated over and over again in the short lines. The harmonious printed image is undermined by a disharmonious sound image and rather impolite meanings.

Let us take a look at the fourth line group. The notation goes like this (underlining means that the word is printed in spaced-out letters):

IV 14 O oo O o / o O o O o O o O o >
 O o O o / oooo O oo O o / O oo OO
 16 ooo O o / o O oo OO o / ooo O ooo O oo OO
 ooo O o / oo O oo OO
 18 o O oo OO o / ooo OO
 O ooo O oo OO // OO

Half of the bottom in all farmers is raised try to / hold on to me when I rush
 trough the club floating farmer-fast / of the whole world and half the junk
 sun I gladly sit with a foxhound in front / of the whole world and a
 foxhound in front / and half of the junk sun I sit in front / preferably with a
 foxhound in front // in front

Lines 14-16 are long lines. I will suggest that the phrases of lines 14-15 are not in rhythmical balance. Compare, for example, the long, bisyllabic phrase in 14:2 with the short, heavy phrase in 15:3. Their rhythmic expressions, respectively, are very different, aiming at

varying ethos. Phrase 14:2 is telling a story, while 15:3 simply expresses strength.

Line 16 establishes two patterns which are then repeated until the end of the line group, an A-pattern and a B-pattern. These two patterns each elaborate two expressions, with some variation in line 18:

ooo O o eller o O o O o (A)
jag sitter gärna, av hela världen
[I gladly sit] [of the whole world]

(o)o O oo OO (o) (B)
med en stövare framför, och hälften av lumpsolen
[with a foxhound in front] [and half of the junk sun]

The A-pattern is to be found in lines 16 (twice) and 17, and the B-pattern in lines 16 (twice), 17, 18, and 19. A distorted version of the A-pattern reappears in line 18 and merges with B in line 19.

The same rhythmic idea is to be seen in the rest of the poem. Every line group repeats a pattern, where rhythmic imbalance dominates the long lines, but phrases balance each other in the short lines. In the fifth line group, for example, the first three lines grow longer and longer, extrapolating an irregularity between phrases. For example, phrase 20:1 is just as short as phrase 21:3, three syllables, but whereas 20:1 is balanced and stable, 21:3 floats away in a vague enjambment. The second phrase of lines 20 and 21 have about the same length (7-8 syllables) but 20:2 is light and quick compared to 21:2, which starts with a prominent monosyllable, building up its heaviness.

V 20 O o O / oo O oo O oo
ooo OO o / O oo O o O o / O oo [>]
22 oo O o / oooo O o O o / oo OO o O oo O o
oo O o / oooo O o O o
24 o O o / oo // o O o
OO o O oo O o // o O o

Farmers extend toward each other in the clubs / in their smoking-coats one
before each heart sweating / after the bath they have run up out of the
world and gotten stone-hard dogs for hearts / after the bath they have run
up out of the world / out of the world and gotten // out of the world /
stone-hard dogs for hearts // out of the world

The short-lined part of the fifth line group is dominated by the spaced-out expression “*ur v ä r l d e n*” ‘out of the world’, which forms a column of its own somewhere in the middle of the printed page. The words are repeated as well as the rhythmic figure, o O o. More than that, phrase 22:1 is repeated in 23:1, phrase 22:2 in 23:2 and the dactylic phrase 22:3 in 25:1.

How does the concept of balance work in this poem? The printed image is beautifully balanced, aiming at visual symmetry. The line groups are imbalanced within themselves (three long lines are followed by three indented short lines), but balance each other.

The lines are divided in contrasting long lines and short ones. The rhythms of the long lines distinguish themselves by a vital untidiness while the short lines repeat a few patterns—however different from one line group to another. This means that half of the lines are characterized by mutual balance and the other half by mutual imbalance.

However, the balancing phrases of the short lines have no internal balance. In the fourth line group their directions are rising, as is the case in the fifth line group, except for line 25, which should be falling. The stoniness of dogs and hearts will be the most important thing here.

7. Balance and equivalence

Talking about repetition and balance in poetry, one will of course be reminded of Roman Jakobson’s principle of equivalence. Since his “Closing Statement” (1958), studies of poetry have acknowledged Roman Jakobson’s idea that the specific lyrical quality originates from repetitions in a poem (Jakobson 1974:150f.). Among other things, Jakobson seems to speak about rhythm here—a simple definition of rhythm says that form elements are repeated. Reuven Tsur discusses Jakobson’s principle of equivalence within a frame of cognitive poetics concerning analogies (Tsur 2002:286f.).

Discussing rhythmical aspects of the poem, we have already seen many examples of repeated phrase rhythm. Instead of ‘equivalent phrases’, I have called them ‘balancing phrases’. By choosing the term ‘balance’, I intend to relate the rhythm of phrases to body rhythms. This bodily connection offers an explanation for the power of equivalent forms (Johnson 1987:85ff.). We feel the flow of rhythm in our kinesthetic bodies, says Mark Johnson (Johnson 2007:239). The power of the flow forms a foundation for meaning.

More than that, using ‘balance’ instead of ‘equivalence’ provides a more nuanced tool. Jakobson’s equivalences never claimed to be exactly similar. They were said to be approximately equal, and the lyrical quality may depend on this approximation. A static repetition of form elements is lifeless and boring, but a dynamic repetition with small divergences evokes the reader’s attention (Danielsen 2006:8-12). Jakobson’s concept of equivalence harmonizes divergences and overlooks the small differences.

The cognitive concept of aesthetic balance, however, implies a conflict between similarity and divergence. In reality, ‘equivalence’ means approximate sameness. ‘Balance’ first hints at perfect balance, and then in the next moment evokes the salience of small differences and focuses on the dynamics of differences within a repeated *gestalt*. This reminds us of what has been said above in section 1 about delayed categorization in poetry, something which produces time enough for a deeper understanding (Tsur 2008:577f.). The fourth line group in the Fahlström poem stands out joyously just because of the small changes to lines 18-19, where ooo O o “*jag sitter gärna*” ‘I gladly sit’ becomes ooo OO “*jag sitter framför*” ‘I sit in front’, and OO “*framför*” ‘in front’ is repeated in an absurd way in the very end of line 19. In versification, there is no difference in substance between ‘equivalence’ and ‘balance’, but using ‘balance’ will underline the importance of dynamic inclinations to imbalance.

Balance includes the possibility of losing it, of falling. The divergence might take over. Dancing to really good rock’n roll gives you the opportunity to lose your point of balance and tumble. That particular moment in which one reaches for a helping hand, and feels the force of one’s own spine, is a very special experience. This utmost edge seems to be a crucial rhythmical quality.

8. Balance in a poem by Plath

In order to develop the tool of balance, I will comment on a final poem, this one by Sylvia Plath. It is one of her very last texts, from October 1962, written a couple of months before she took her own life.

- Even the sun-clouds this morning cannot manage such skirts.
 2 Nor the woman in the ambulance
 Whose red heart blooms through her coat astoundingly ----

- 4 A gift, a love gift
Utterly unasked for
6 By a sky
- Palely and flamily
8 Igniting its carbon monoxides, by eyes
Dulled to a halt under bowlers.
- 10 O my God, what am I
That these late mouths should cry open
12 In a forest of frost, in a dawn of cornflowers.
(Poppies in October, *Collected Poems* 240)

What happens in this poem? The title says that it is about flowers, poppies, which are never really mentioned in the text. But probably “such skirts” (line 1) describe poppies, and the bleeding heart of “the woman in the ambulance” (line 2) is compared to poppies just like the “sun-clouds” in line 1 and the flaming “sky” of lines 6-8. Also the “gift” (line 4) and the “mouths” (line 11) may allude to poppies.

The narrative tells us about a woman who has attempted suicide (or perhaps been shot) and is now being transported to a hospital. It is an early morning in October, the weather could be better, and men are rushing to their jobs. In the last stanza, the ‘I’ of the poem listens to the screaming mouths of the poppies. The leading symbol of the poem, the poppies, seems to stand for the fear of death. Here the notation of rhythm:

		<u>prominences</u>	<u>syllable stress ratio</u>
	O oo OO OO o / oo O o OO	5 + 3 = 8	1.8
2	O o O o / oo O oo	2 1 3	3
	o OOO / oo O o O oo	3 2 5	2.2 (1.3 3.5)
4	o O / o OO >	1 2 3	1.9
	O ooo OO >	3 3	2
6	oo O >	1 1	3
	O ooo O oo	2 2	3.5
8	o O oo O o O o 0 / o O >	4 1 5	2.2
	O oo O oo O o	3 3	2.7
10	O o O / o OO	2 2 4	1.8
	o OOO / o OO o	3 2 5	1.6 (1.3 2)
12	oo O oo O / oo O o OO o	2 3 5	2.6 (3 2.3)

Discussing the rhythm of this poem I would like to further develop the concept of balance regarding poetry. Following Mark Johnson, the bodily experience of balance includes weight and pressure (1987:85, 98). In other words, 'balance' might be understood as the combinations and relations of weight (or intensity, or simply more sound) and pressure (or force, or direction) in a poem. Intensity as well as direction works both in time and in space. Transferred to the language of versification, they entail a concentration on devices like syllable stress ratio, prominences (for weight or intensity), and phrase or line focus, including enjambments (for pressure or direction). One will find the same parameters when using the rhythmic tool of prolongation (Cureton 1992:146f.).

The stanza lengths of this poem balance each other, 3-3-3-3 lines. The printed image of the poem is a common one from a historical perspective—a straight left margin and a wavering right margin, just like the Tranströmer poem in section 2. The line lengths contrast between stanzas. The long lines of the first stanza (8-3-5 prominences) in particular differ from the short lines of the second stanza (3-3-1 prominences). The emptiness of the white paper is attacking the text, especially in the second stanza. The first and fourth stanzas are about balancing each other concerning line length (8-3-5, 4-5-5 prominences).

The figures are weighted or directed. There are some heavy figures, spondees and molossus, with a concentration on the first and the last stanza. The second and third stanzas consist of one long sentence, which forms a falling unity—the gift of line 4 offers the hot kernel of the passage. The third stanza (lines 7-9) has a vague tactus which contrasts with the heavy antique figures of the other stanzas (OO, OOO). Line 7 may be read in dipodic trochees: O o O o | O o O. There is one strong enjambment in line 8. Other figures of interest are the dactylus row in line 9 and the anapests in line 12 with their obvious directions, falling and rising respectively.

Let us take a closer look at the heavy figures of lines 1 (three spondees) and 3 (one molossus) in the first stanza, lines 4 and 5 in the second stanza (two spondees), and lines 10 (one spondee), 11 (one molossus and one spondee), and 12 (one weak spondee) in the fourth stanza.

- 1 “sun-clouds | this morning”, “such skirts”
- 3 “red heart blooms”
- 4 “love gift”,
- 5 “unasked for”
- 10 “am I”
- 11 “these late mouths”, “cry open”
- 12 “cornflowers”

Syllable stress ratio gives extra weight to lines 1, 4, 10 and 11. In all these lines the ratio is less than 2, which means that the line consists of more prominences than weak syllables. This is contrary to normal prosody and something which occurs rarely, but which we already have observed in the Tranströmer poem in section 2. Their weight emphasizes these lines as the most significant passages of the poem. Lines 1, 4, 5 and 10 are closed by spondees, which yields a heavy forward movement. Line 11 seems to stand still with its heavy burden of prominences and lack of rising as well as falling directions.

Elsewhere, phrase and line directions are, in my reading, mostly rising. The second and third stanzas are moving forward on the line level with the help of enjambments—one of them even bypasses the pause between stanzas. This means that semantic meaning and phrasal rhythm are in conflict here, since the semantic center of those two stanzas must be the “love gift” of line 4, which is extended in lines 5-9.

What do rhythmical weight and pressure mean for the interpretation? The spondaic enjambments of lines 1, 4, 5 and 10 combine weight and pressure, but the heaviness of phrase in 1:1 and all of line 11 make those passages simply immovable. The reader is forced to linger. The second stanza combines weight with a strong forward movement which takes over in the third stanza, and which closes the passage with the calm line 9.

I propose that the rising acoustic movement underlines some aspects of the narrative. A heavy forward dash could icon panic, an emotion that seems to underlie the narrative of the poem. I would say that the main theme here is fear of death. Does this heavy rush add something to this subject? What about death rushing forward to you? It sounds terrifying, and I suggest that terror is the dominating ethos. Form strengthens the narrative in this poem.

I can find two resting points in this poem, line 9 and line 12. The falling dactylus row of line 9, telling about the dulled clerks, looks

away from catastrophe, and by then the reader will need some escape. More remarkable is the rising anapestic beauty of line 12, which closes the poem. Red poppies become blue cornflowers, and the late cry is silenced in a forest of frost.

Weight, pressure and resting points interrelate and combine in a poem in balance. One may compare this poetic rhythm with the Hermes of Boccioni, at the same time heavy and rushing, yet nevertheless in balance.

9. Conclusion

In this chapter, I have set forth three principles of rhythm: serial, sequential and dynamic rhythm. I have also investigated how the image schema of balance could be used for analysing rhythm. Thereby, I have developed the concept of balance focusing on dynamic repetition instead of static repetition. I have also transferred the qualities of pressure and weight into the language of versification.

This is a report from a work in progress. It is probably too early to formulate a definition of aesthetic rhythm, but a few things could be said. Rhythm is a quality created in the perception of a work of art. Form impulses are patterned into *gestalts*, audible and visual. Rhythm concerns the relationship within and between the form elements of a work of art. Of particular interest is whether or not they balance. Inclinations to imbalance in the sequences cause movements and directions within the *gestalts* (dynamic repetition). 'Rhythm' signifies the (perception of) contrast between balance and movement, rest and conflict in a work of art, as in a poem.

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